AppealDesk

Your Homeowner Savings Guide

Prepared for: **Alex Morgan**
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Property Tax Exemptions & Credits You May Qualify For

Based on your property in Harris County, Texas, we have identified the following property tax exemption and credit programs that may apply to you. Each program listed below includes eligibility requirements, estimated savings, and instructions for how to apply. *Since we do not collect personal information such as age or veteran status, each program below is listed as "If you qualify..." so you can identify which programs may apply to your household.*

General Residence Homestead Exemption

Reduces your home's taxable value by $100,000 for school district taxes. Many cities and counties offer additional local homestead exemptions of 1%-20% of assessed value.

Estimated Savings: $1,200-$2,500/year

Eligibility: Primary residence as of January 1. You must own the property and occupy it as your principal residence.
Deadline: April 30 (late applications accepted up to 2 years after deadline)
Form: Form 50-114
Apply: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/exemptions/residence-homestead.php
File once with your county appraisal district. Does not need annual renewal unless you move.

Over-65 Homestead Exemption

Additional $10,000 exemption from school district taxes on top of the general homestead exemption. Many local taxing units offer additional exemptions of $3,000-$75,000+ for residents 65 and older. Also freezes your school district tax ceiling.

Estimated Savings: $300-$1,500/year (plus tax ceiling freeze)

Eligibility: Must be 65 or older as of January 1 and qualify for the general homestead exemption.
Deadline: April 30 (late applications accepted up to 2 years after deadline)
Form: Form 50-114
Apply: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/exemptions/residence-homestead.php
The school district tax ceiling freeze means your school taxes will never increase above the amount due the year you turned 65 or qualified, regardless of rising property values. Surviving spouse 55+ may retain the ceiling.

Disabled Veteran Exemption
Exemption ranging from $5,000 to $12,000 based on disability rating (10%-100%). Veterans with 100% disability rating receive a full exemption on their homestead. Surviving spouses may also qualify.

Estimated Savings: $150-$5,000+/year (full exemption for 100% disabled)

Eligibility: Must be a Texas resident and have a VA-rated disability of at least 10%.
Deadline: April 30
Form: Form 50-135
Apply: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/exemptions/disabled-veteran-exemption.php
A 100% disabled veteran pays zero property taxes on their homestead. Surviving spouses of veterans killed in action may also receive a full exemption.

Disability Homestead Exemption
Additional $10,000 exemption from school district taxes for homeowners who are disabled. Many local taxing units offer additional exemptions. Also freezes your school district tax ceiling.

Estimated Savings: $300-$1,500/year (plus tax ceiling freeze)

Eligibility: Must qualify for disability under Social Security or have a disability rating of at least 10% from the VA.
Deadline: April 30
Form: Form 50-114
Apply: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/exemptions/residence-homestead.php
Cannot receive both the Over-65 and Disability exemptions simultaneously. You may choose whichever provides greater benefit.

Surviving Spouse of Armed Forces Member
Full exemption from property taxes for the surviving spouse of a member of the armed forces killed in the line of duty.

Estimated Savings: Full property tax exemption

Eligibility: Surviving spouse of a member of the U.S. armed forces killed in action or who died while on active duty. Must not have remarried.
Deadline: April 30
Form: Form 50-114
Apply: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/exemptions/residence-homestead.php

Surviving spouses of first responders killed in the line of duty may also qualify for a full exemption.

Homestead Cap (10% Annual Increase Limit)
Limits the appraised value of your homestead to no more than 10% increase per year above the prior year's value, plus the value of any new improvements.

Estimated Savings: Varies significantly based on market appreciation

Eligibility: Automatic for all properties with a general homestead exemption.
Deadline: Automatic with homestead exemption filing
This cap applies automatically when you have a homestead exemption. In rapidly appreciating markets, this can save thousands per year. The cap resets when you sell your home.

Agricultural (1-d-1) Appraisal
Land used primarily for agriculture, timber, or wildlife management is appraised based on its productive capacity rather than market value.

Estimated Savings: Often reduces land value by 80-95%

Eligibility: Land must be devoted principally to agricultural use. Minimum acreage and activity requirements vary by county.

Tax Deferral for Age 65+ or Disabled
Allows eligible homeowners to defer (postpone) payment of property taxes on their homestead without penalty.

Estimated Savings: Defers all taxes above $0 (taxes accrue 5% annual interest)

Eligibility: Must be 65 or older or disabled. File an affidavit with the county tax office.

Source: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/property-tax/exemptions/
These programs are independent of your property assessment. You can apply for exemptions regardless of whether you file a property tax appeal. Even if your assessment is accurate, you may be overpaying taxes simply because you have not applied for exemptions you qualify for.
Exemption programs and eligibility requirements change periodically. The information above is current as of 2026-03. Verify current requirements with your county assessor's office before applying.

Reassessment Protection Guide

Understanding what triggers a reassessment of your property can help you protect your current assessed value and avoid unexpected tax increases.

Texas Homestead Cap Protection
If you have a homestead exemption, your appraised value cannot increase by more than 10% per year (plus any new improvements). This cap is automatic once your homestead exemption is in place.
Texas appraisal districts reassess every property annually. The cap limits the increase, but you can still protest your value every year if you believe it exceeds market value.

Actions That May Trigger Reassessment

- **Building permits:** Pulling a permit for renovations, additions, or structural changes will typically notify the assessor of improvements to your property.
- **Major visible renovations:** Exterior improvements such as new roofing, siding, additions, or added structures (pools, garages, ADUs) may prompt a reassessment even without a permit.
- **Listing on MLS:** Listing your home for sale, even temporarily, can expose a higher market value to the assessor, especially if the listing price significantly exceeds your current assessed value.
- **Refinance appraisals:** In some jurisdictions, a high appraisal obtained during refinancing can become part of the public record and influence your assessment.
- **Insurance rebuild valuations:** Replacement cost estimates from insurance claims can signal a higher property value.
- **Adding structures:** Pools, accessory dwelling units (ADUs), detached garages, and other permanent structures increase your property's value.

How to Protect Your Current Assessment

- **Document your home's current condition:** Take dated photos showing any deferred maintenance, needed repairs, or functional issues. This documentation can support a lower valuation if challenged.
- **Keep records of needed repairs:** Maintain a list of deferred maintenance items (aging HVAC, roof wear, plumbing issues). These reduce your home's value relative to comparable properties.
- **Understand your reassessment schedule:** Know when your county's next reassessment year is so you are not caught off guard by changes.
- **Review your annual assessment notice:** When you receive your notice of assessed value, compare it to the prior year and to recent comparable sales in your neighborhood.

Your state's reassessment cycle: Texas reassesses property on a annual basis. Understanding this cycle helps you anticipate when your assessment might change.

What to Do If Your Assessment Increases

If your assessed value increases significantly, you have the right to protest. The key steps are:

- Review your protest deadline (see the Appeal Window section of this packet)
- Gather comparable sales data showing your home's actual market value
- Document any property-specific factors that reduce value (condition issues, location drawbacks, functional obsolescence)
- File your protest before the deadline

AppealDesk can generate a comprehensive evidence packet if your assessment rises in the future. Visit https://www.appealdesk.com to get started.

Understanding Your Property Tax Bill

Your property tax bill includes more than just the base property tax. Understanding each component helps you identify which charges can be challenged and where potential savings exist.

How Your Tax Is Calculated

The core formula is: **Assessed Value x Tax Rate = Base Property Tax**. Your total bill then adds special district assessments, voter-approved bonds, and various fees on top of this base amount.

Common Line Items You May See

- **School district levy:** Typically the largest portion (often 40-50% of total). Funds local public schools and sometimes community colleges.
- **County general fund:** Covers county services including roads, courts, public safety, and administration.
- **City/municipal tax:** Funds city services such as police, fire, parks, and infrastructure. Only applies if you live within city limits.
- **Fire/emergency services district:** Funds local fire protection and emergency medical services. Common in unincorporated areas.
- **Library district:** Funds local library operations and programs.
- **Stormwater/drainage fees:** Based on impervious surface area. Some jurisdictions bill these separately from the tax bill.
- **Voter-approved bonds:** Debt service on bonds approved by voters for schools, infrastructure, parks, or other public projects.
- **Solid waste assessment:** Some jurisdictions include trash collection fees on the property tax bill.
- **Special improvement districts:** Charges for lighting, sidewalks, or other neighborhood-level improvements.

Which Charges Can Be Challenged?

Challengeable **Ad valorem (value-based) taxes:** The core property tax based on your assessed value. This is what a property tax appeal addresses. Reducing your assessed value reduces this portion of your bill proportionally.

Separate Process **Special assessments and fees:** Flat-rate charges for specific services (stormwater, solid waste, special districts) often have their own dispute process. Contact your county for details.

Not Challengeable **Voter-approved bonds:** Bond levies approved at the ballot box generally cannot be individually challenged through the appeal process.

Where Your Tax Dollars Typically Go

While the exact breakdown varies by jurisdiction, a typical distribution of property tax revenue is:

~45%	~25%	~15%	~15%
Schools	County Services	City/Municipal	Special Districts

These are national averages. Your jurisdiction's breakdown may differ. Check your tax bill or county website for the exact distribution.

Energy Savings & Rebate Finder

Beyond property tax savings, significant financial incentives are available for home energy improvements. Many homeowners are unaware of these programs, which can save hundreds to thousands of dollars per year on energy costs.

Federal Programs (Available Nationwide)

Energy Efficient Home Improvement Credit (25C)
Tax credit of up to $3,200/year for qualifying home energy improvements including insulation, exterior doors, windows, central air conditioners, heat pumps, water heaters, and electrical panel upgrades.

Up to $3,200/year ($1,200 general limit + $2,000 for heat pumps/heat pump water heaters)

Eligibility: Available to all homeowners for improvements to their primary residence. Must meet ENERGY STAR or other efficiency standards.
How to claim: Claim on your federal tax return using IRS Form 5695. Keep receipts and manufacturer certification statements.
Available through: Through December 31, 2032
Details: https://www.energystar.gov/about/federal_tax_credits/tax_credits_702

Residential Clean Energy Credit (25D)
30% tax credit on the cost of solar panels, solar water heaters, battery storage, geothermal heat pumps, fuel cells, and small wind turbines.

30% of total system cost (no maximum limit)

Eligibility: Available to homeowners for installations on any home they own (primary or secondary). Must be a new installation, not previously used.
How to claim: Claim on your federal tax return using IRS Form 5695. Unused credit can carry forward to future tax years.
Available through: 30% through 2032, then 26% in 2033, 22% in 2034
Details:
https://www.energystar.gov/about/federal_tax_credits/renewable_energy_tax_credits

High-Efficiency Electric Home Rebate Act (HEEHRA)
Point-of-sale rebates for electrification upgrades: up to $8,000 for heat pumps, $1,750 for heat pump water heaters, $840 for electric stoves/dryers, $4,000 for electrical panel upgrades, and $1,600 for insulation.

Up to $14,000 total in rebates per household

Eligibility: Income-qualified: households earning less than 150% of area median income get the largest rebates. Moderate-income households (150-200% AMI) get

50% rebates. Above 200% AMI are not eligible for HEEHRA rebates.
How to claim: Applied as a point-of-sale discount through participating contractors. Check with your state energy office for availability.
Available through: Funds available until September 30, 2031 or until exhausted
Details: https://www.energy.gov/scep/home-energy-rebates-programs

Texas Programs

Texas PACE Program (Property Assessed Clean Energy)
Financing for commercial and residential energy efficiency and renewable energy improvements through property tax assessments.
Details: https://www.texaspaceauthority.org/
Availability varies by municipality. Check if your city has opted in to the PACE program.

Utility Rebate Programs
Major Texas utilities (Oncor, CenterPoint, AEP Texas) offer rebates for ENERGY STAR appliances, smart thermostats, insulation, and HVAC upgrades.
Contact your electric utility directly for current rebate offers. Rebates typically range from $50-$1,500 depending on the upgrade.

Texas LoanSTAR Program
Low-interest loans for energy efficiency retrofits in public buildings and some residential programs through participating lenders.
Details: https://comptroller.texas.gov/programs/seco/loanstar/
Primarily for public sector, but some local programs extend to residential through participating utilities.

Texas has a deregulated electricity market. Check with your specific retail electricity provider (Oncor, CenterPoint, AEP) for available rebates on ENERGY STAR equipment and efficiency upgrades.

Where to Start

For maximum savings, energy efficiency experts recommend this order of improvements:

1. **Air sealing and insulation first.** This has the highest return on investment and enables right-sizing of HVAC equipment. Typical savings: 15-30% on heating and cooling costs.
2. **HVAC heat pump upgrade.** Heat pumps provide both heating and cooling, qualify for the largest rebates, and can reduce energy costs by 30-50% compared to traditional systems.
3. **Water heater replacement.** Heat pump water heaters use 60-70% less energy than conventional models and qualify for substantial rebates.

Federal tax credits require filing IRS Form 5695 with your annual tax return. State and utility programs may have different application processes. Program availability and amounts are

subject to change. Consult with a tax professional regarding your specific eligibility.

Property Tax Watch: Continuous Assessment Monitoring

As more comparable sales data becomes available in your area, your case for an appeal may strengthen. Property Tax Watch monitors your assessment year-round and alerts you to changes and new opportunities.

- ✓ **Annual assessment change alerts** delivered to your inbox when your county updates your property value
- ✓ **Automatic overassessment detection** comparing your assessed value against current market data
- ✓ **Filing deadline reminders** so you never miss your window to appeal

Activate Your Free 12-Month Monitoring

https://www.appealdesk.com/tax-watch

Protest Window & Deadline Summary

In Texas, the process for challenging your property assessment is called a "protest." Here is what you need to know about timing and deadlines for Harris County.

Mark Your Calendar
Texas Protest Deadline: May 15 or May 31 with extension
Review Board: Appraisal Review Board (ARB)
County: Harris County, Texas

The typical protest window in Texas is **April – May**. During this period, homeowners can file a formal protest of their assessed property value.

When Your Protest Window Opens
Your protest window typically opens when you receive your **Notice of Appraised Value** from the county. This notice is mailed to property owners, usually in the spring. **Keep this notice.** You will need it to file your protest. It contains your property identification number, current assessed value, and instructions for filing.

Texas Protest Process

If you choose to protest, the process follows these levels:

1. Appraisal District (Informal)
2. Appraisal Review Board (ARB)
3. District Court / Binding Arbitration
4. State Office of Administrative Hearings (SOAH)

An **informal review** is available before the formal hearing in most jurisdictions. This is often the fastest path to resolution.

If you need a complete evidence packet to support your protest, AppealDesk can generate one with comparable sales analysis, a cover letter, and filing instructions tailored to your property. Visit https://www.appealdesk.com to get started.

This guide is for informational purposes. Exemption eligibility and program details should be verified with your county assessor's office before applying. Energy rebate programs are subject to change and funding availability. Consult with a tax professional regarding your specific eligibility for tax credits.